

CAROLINA PANTHERS INTEL REPORT

2026 training camp edition — first playoff berth since 2017, the offseason's biggest edge contract, and a rebuild the league now describes as ahead of schedule.

UPDATED
July 25, 2026

Playoffs

2025 — FIRST SINCE 2017

Dave Canales

HEAD COACH

Dan Morgan

GENERAL MANAGER

\$120M

PHILLIPS CONTRACT

First

TEAM FULLY REPORTED

◆ FRONT OFFICE & LEADERSHIP

- ◆ **Morgan went hunting for pass rush.** The GM said quarterback pressure in 2025 was **"not acceptable"** and promised to be aggressive about it. He then wrote the largest edge contract of the offseason.
- ◆ **Canales hands off the play sheet.** Offensive coordinator **Brad Idzik** takes over play-calling from the head coach — a real change in how this offense operates day to day, and the quietest big story of the camp.
- ◆ **Scheme fit was the sell.** Jaelan Phillips thrived under Vic Fangio in Philadelphia, and Carolina runs a similar 3-4 with the flexibility to shift to a 4-3 — the front office's explicit reasoning for the price.
- ◆ **Camp readiness:** Carolina and Arizona were the **first two teams in the NFL to fully report** for 2026 camp.

◆ TRADES & MAJOR TRANSACTIONS

- ◆ **SIGNED** **Jaelan Phillips, EDGE** — four years, **\$120M** with \$80M guaranteed, prised away from Philadelphia. He ranked **ninth in the NFL in quarterback pressures (73)** in 2025.
- ◆ **SIGNED** **Devin Lloyd, LB** — three years, \$45M, from Jacksonville.
- ◆ **SIGNED** WR **John Metchie III**, reuniting with his college quarterback. In their last season together in 2021 he posted a team-high 96 catches for 1,142 yards and eight scores.
- ◆ **SIGNED** QB **Kenny Pickett** to the backup job.
- ◆ **TRADE** QB **Andy Dalton to Philadelphia** on a three-year, \$24.75M deal.
- ◆ **DRAFT** Six of seven picks signed, including OT **Monroe Freeling** and WR **Chris Brazzell**.

◆ PLAYER UPDATES & CAMP BATTLES

- ◆ **Bryce Young, QB.** Career-best season — first time past **3,000 yards and 20 touchdown passes** — and he led Carolina back to the playoffs. The counterargument is still on the stat sheet: EPA per dropback third-worst among qualified starters, QBR 25th. Year 4 is the verdict year.
- ◆ **Tetairoa McMillan, WR.** Coming off an award-winning rookie season. His ascension is the offense's most likely leap.
- ◆ **A crowded receiver room.** Xavier Legette, Chris Brazzell and Jimmy Horn Jr. are all competing for the snaps behind McMillan — chemistry with Young is the tiebreaker.
- ◆ **Jaelan Phillips, EDGE.** \$120M arrives to fix the pressure problem by himself if necessary.
- ◆ **Devin Lloyd, LB.** Adds range and downhill play behind the new front.
- ◆ **Offensive line health** is the open question — injuries have muddled how the front five sorts out.

◆ LATEST ROSTER MOVES

MOVE	DETAIL
▲ Jaelan Phillips, EDGE	4 yr / \$120M, \$80M guaranteed
▲ Devin Lloyd, LB	3 yr / \$45M from Jacksonville
▲ John Metchie III, WR	Reunited with Bryce Young
▲ Kenny Pickett, QB	Signed as the veteran backup
▲ Monroe Freeling, OT	Rookie deal signed
▲ Chris Brazzell, WR	Rookie deal signed
▼ Andy Dalton, QB	Traded to Philadelphia

◆ THE BOTTOM LINE

Carolina got to January a year early, and Dan Morgan responded by paying full price for the one thing that keeps you there: pressure. **Phillips and Lloyd cost \$165M combined**, and both fit a front that can flip between 3-4 and 4-3. The offense is the more interesting experiment — Brad Idzik now calls it, McMillan is ready for more, and Bryce Young has to prove that a playoff season was a floor rather than a ceiling. The underlying numbers still say the jury is out.